

News Analytics Chatbot with Val

A step-by-step guide for the News Analytics group activity (slides 28-31): build a custom Val persona whose system prompt turns any news article into a structured summary table.

Activity is designed by Su Nguyen; Detailed guide is drafted by Claude Cowork.

Before you start

You need an RMIT account to log in to Val (val.rmit.edu.au). Pick a recent news topic your group cares about (the slide example is the housing market). Decide what structured output you want before you start - here we use a table of Headline, Summary, Author, Publisher, Date and Key Topics.

Plan	Define your workflow, inputs and output format
Create	My Studio -> Create Persona with a news-analytics system prompt
Test	Open the persona and paste a news article
Result	Get a structured summary table you can reuse for any article
Share	Present your chatbot to the class and refine the prompt

A companion screen recording (Week5_News_Analytics_Val.gif) shows every click in sequence.

Step 1 - Plan your workflow (Slide 30)

Before touching Val, agree as a group on three things - this is the real skill the activity is teaching:

- Inputs: how will you give the chatbot the news? (paste the article text, attach a screenshot/PDF, or both)
- Output format: what structure do you want back? Here: a table with Headline, Summary, Author(s), Publisher/Source, Date and Key Topics.
- System prompt: the instructions that make the chatbot behave consistently every time.

Step 2 - Create the persona in Val (Slides 28-29)

Log in to Val, open My Studio, and click Create Persona. Give it a name, choose a base model, and paste your system prompt. Turn on Vision so it can also read images/screenshots of articles.

Example system prompt:

You are a News Analytics Assistant. The user will give you one or more news articles as text, and may also attach images or screenshots. Analyse each article and return ONLY a Markdown table with one row per article and these columns: Headline | Summary (2-3 sentences) | Key Author(s) | Publisher / Source | Date Published | Key Topics. Base every field strictly on the article provided - if a field is not stated, write 'Not stated'. After the table, add one short line beginning 'Key takeaway:'. Do not add any other commentary.

The screenshot shows the 'Create Persona' form in the RMIT News Analytics Assistant interface. The form is titled 'News Analytics Assistant' and includes the following fields:

- Default Base Model:** OpenAI GPT-4o
- Description:** Analyses news articles (text and images) and returns a structured summary table.
- Persona Params:**
 - System Prompt:** You are a News Analytics Assistant. The user will give you one or more news articles as text, and may also attach images or screenshots. Analyse each article and return ONLY a Markdown table with one row per article and these columns: Headline | Summary (2-3 sentences) | Key Author(s) | Publisher / Source | Date Published | Key Topics. Base every field strictly on the article provided - if a field is not stated, write 'Not stated'. After the table, add one short line beginning 'Key takeaway:'. Do not add any other commentary.
 - Advanced Params:** (Collapsed)
 - Prompt suggestions:** (Collapsed)
- Knowledge:** To attach a knowledge base here, create one under the "Knowledge" area first, and ensure you upload at least one content file to it. A 'Select Knowledge' button is visible.
- Capabilities:** Vision and Citations are both checked.

A 'Save & Create' button is located at the bottom right of the form. The interface also shows a sidebar with navigation options like 'New Chat', 'My Studio', 'Provide Feedback', and 'Chat History'. The user's name 'Su Nguyen' is visible in the bottom left corner.

Figure 1 - The Create Persona form: name, base model (GPT-4o), description and the system prompt.

Step 3 - Save the persona

Click Save & Create. Your new persona appears in My Personas, ready to use and share.

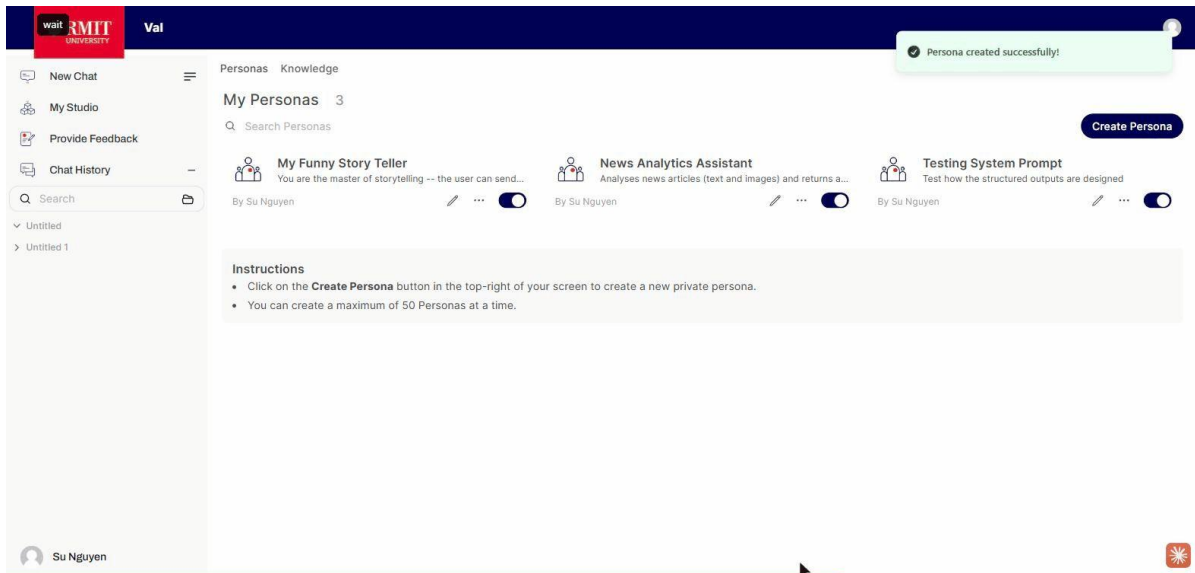


Figure 2 - Persona created - News Analytics Assistant now sits in My Studio.

Tip: if Save does nothing, make sure you have selected a Default Base Model - it is required.

Step 4 - Open the persona to test

Click the persona to start a chat with it. The message bar shows your persona name and the chosen model, so every message follows your system prompt.

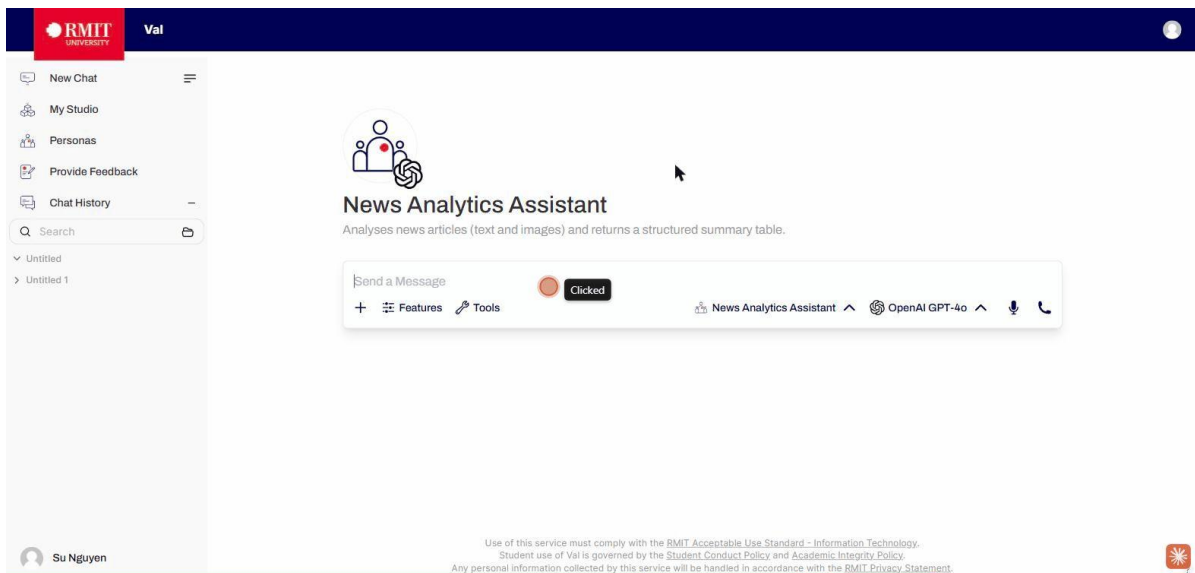


Figure 3 - A fresh chat running the News Analytics Assistant persona.

Step 5 - Analyse a news article (Slides 30-31)

Paste a news article (or attach a screenshot) and send. The persona returns exactly the structured table you designed - no matter which article you give it. Below is a housing-market story turned into a clean summary.

The screenshot shows the Val chatbot interface with a sidebar on the left containing options like 'New Chat', 'My Studio', 'Personas', 'Provide Feedback', 'Chat History', and a search bar. The main chat area displays a structured table output for a news article. The table has columns: HEADLINE, SUMMARY, KEY AUTHOR(S), PUBLISHER / SOURCE, DATE PUBLISHED, and KEY TOPICS. Below the table is a 'Key takeaway' section. At the bottom, there is a 'Send a Message' input field and a footer with RMIT University branding and a disclaimer.

HEADLINE	SUMMARY	KEY AUTHOR(S)	PUBLISHER / SOURCE	DATE PUBLISHED	KEY TOPICS
Home prices rise as first-home buyers, investors see intense competition	Australian house prices are predicted to grow by 7.7% in 2026, with Perth leading at nearly 13% growth, followed by Brisbane and Darwin at over 10%. Intense competition at the affordable end of the market is driven by first-home buyers using the federal government's 5% deposit scheme, alongside investors and upgraders, amidst a shortage of listings.	Brendan Rynne (quoted)	Money Magazine (moneymag.com.au)	24 January 2026	Australian real estate, house prices, first-home buyers, federal policy on housing, housing shortages

Key takeaway: Housing demand and limited supply are driving significant price growth, particularly in lower-priced markets.

This response was generated by a persona created by a community member.

Val is an AI assistant which does not have access to real-time internet data without web search first being enabled. Student and academic use of Val must adhere to policies available at [Student rights and responsibilities](#).

Send a Message

+ Features Tools

News Analytics Assistant OpenAI GPT-4o

Su Nguyen

Use of this service must comply with the RMIT Acceptable Use Standard - Information Technology. Student use of Val is governed by the Student Conduct Policy and Academic Integrity Policy. Any personal information collected by this service will be handled in accordance with the RMIT Privacy Statement.

Figure 4 - The structured output: headline, summary, author, publisher, date, key topics and a key takeaway.

To share with the class: present your chatbot, show a couple of articles run through it, and discuss how you'd refine the prompt (e.g. add columns, change tone, or ask for an infographic/mind map instead of a table).

Good to know

- The system prompt is what makes outputs consistent - small wording changes (column names, 'ONLY a table', 'if not stated write Not stated') noticeably change the result. Iterate.
- Turn on Vision in the persona so students can drop in screenshots of articles, not just text.
- Val responses are non-deterministic; for serious analysis, always sanity-check the extracted facts against the original article.
- Each group member can create their own persona and compare outputs - a good way to see how prompt design affects quality.
- Val notes it has no real-time internet access unless web search is enabled, so paste the article rather than just linking to it.